

Upgrade your online security

The recent hack on a journalist's online accounts highlights how woefully out of date our security practices are

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A few weeks ago, Mat Honan, a writer at Wired magazine got his online accounts hacked. Yes, that's 'accounts' as in plural. In a matter of an hour, Mat Honan's iPhone, iPad and Macbook were wiped clean of their data by hackers who got into his iCloud account. Next, they proceeded to gain access to his Google account and subsequently deleted it. The motive? Mat's three-letter Twitter handle – '@mat'. The hackers saw the lucrative handle and decided to go after it, using whatever means they saw necessary. The only tool they needed, were a couple of phone calls.

In a scary coincidence, Amazon and Apple's contrasting security policies, along with some carelessness on Mat's part led to him losing access to all his digital accounts along with all of his data (including pictures of his one-year-old daughter). Apparently, Amazon displays the last four digits of the account holder's credit card publicly, but Apple uses these very same last four digits to confirm your identity over the phone. Using this loophole in the operating procedure of the two tech giants, the hackers gained access to Mat's iCloud account and used a temporary password to remotely wipe his Macbook, iPad and iPhone. Since Mat used his Mobile Me address as a secondary address for his Gmail, they were able to obtain his Gmail credentials with ease.

Since his Gmail address was linked to his Twitter account, the hackers reset his Twitter password and gained access to his Twitter handle.

The hack was successful for a lot of reasons, but it could have been entirely avoided with a few precautions. Mat (and most of us) use security practices that were cultivated in the early days of the internet. But in this day and age where we store such a great deal of our personal data on the cloud, these practices need some reviewing. One example is the traditional approach of using a 'strong' password, or even different passwords on all your online accounts. The hackers didn't use any 'traditional' techniques to break into his accounts and they never needed to use Mat's original passwords to any of his accounts.

There are several lessons one can learn from this incident. First and most importantly backup all your online and offline data, redundantly. The term 'redundantly' is important here, as having multiple copies of your data in different places is a sure step towards mitigating the effects of a hack. When making backups, make sure you make both online and offline backups, make sure the backups are securely encrypted, and if possibly use an automated backup mechanism so you don't have to bother with it yourself. (Note that tools

like Dropbox and Google Drive aren't exactly backup solutions, they're more suited for file syncing. With a few tweaks however, they can be adapted to our needs)

For offline backups, we prefer a program like Crashplan (www.crashplan.com) which automates the entire process. The application works on practically all platforms (Windows, Mac, Linux and Solaris), is completely free of cost and can simultaneously backup

like to have backed up, and let Crashplan take care of the rest. Note that Crashplan can also backup to locations on the cloud, but you'll need to subscribe to the paid Crashplan+ plan.

Instead, assuming you're already a user of cloud storage via a service like Dropbox or Google Drive, you can leverage this space and configure it as a destination for your Crashplan backups. This ensures you'll always have a local copy on your working machine along with a copy on the cloud. Furthermore, since we're using Crashplan to encrypt our backups, in the event your cloud credentials are compromised, your personal data should be reasonably safe. As a thumb rule, any critical data you store online **MUST** be encrypted. You can compress and encrypt your data yourself using a password protected archive file format like .7z

(www.7-zip.org)

Now that you've safely set up a backup system, let's turn our attention to the real threat: your online accounts. That passwords aren't the safest way to protect your account is quite well established. The old rules of using unique, strong passwords for your accounts still stand, of course. If you're worried you may not be able to remember a dozen or so passwords, let a program do it for you. Password managers such as Lastpass (www.lastpass.com)



Crashplan provides an automated, flexible solution for all your backup needs

your data to multiple locations for you. All backups are compressed with a highly optimised algorithm and securely encrypted, can be scheduled and fully automated. There is no limit on the file size or total size of the backup; the only restriction is the size of your physical drive. We recommend using an external hard drive that remains attached to your main computer at all times. (If your wireless router has a USB port, that's the ideal place to attach the drive). Download the application, set up the directories you would